

categories known as newsgroups. The “Big-eight” set of worldwide newsgroups that exist currently are:

- Comp.*: Computer-related
- News.*: Discussions and announcements about news
- Sci.*: Science-related discussions
- Soc.*: Social discussions
- Talk.*: Talk about controversial topics
- Rec.*: Recreation and Entertainment
- Humanities.*: Fine Arts, Literature, and Philosophy
- Misc.*: Miscellaneous topics

The USENET resembles the Bulletin Board System (BBS), and is termed the predecessor to a large number of Web site forums that exist even today.

Now, with so many Web-based forums, blogs, mailing lists, and so on, the use of the USENET is diminishing—in fact, it has become quite niche.

VisiCalc Meant Business

The Apple II personal computer turned into a business machine after VisiCalc was developed by Harvard MBA candidate Daniel Bricklin and programmer Robert Frankston in 1979. It was the first spreadsheet-like program to be developed, as we’ve mentioned. The program was developed by Software Arts and distributed by Personal Software, later named VisiCorp.

Bricklin got the idea of VisiCalc while he was at Harvard and watched the university professor erasing and re-writing the faulty entries of a financial model on the blackboard. He then realised that the same process could be replicated using an e-spreadsheet.